

Freecom MusicPal

Satellite Radios Look Out!

Many activities that normally revolve around the computer are now are now moving out to dedicated devices. The Freecom MusicPal—a dedicated Internet radio is a perfect example of this. It connects to the Internet wirelessly as well as through a wired Ethernet connection.

The device is shaped to act as a stand for itself. The front has two big knobs that feel like anti-bacterial material. The feel of the dials is squishy and also a little wobbly. They are the two most important controls used for the player. Two other buttons—menu and favourites—are available. It has a black and white screen as its main display.

The player connects to Internet stations from an online database and also those from Shoutcast. Streaming works fine as long as you have enough bandwidth. The variety of music streams is vast and

well-categorised. The player can also be controlled and customised through a Web interface. The same can be done through the player, but using only the dials to cycle through characters is both slow and painful.

The player has many more features other than the ability to stream music over the Internet. It also sports an RSS feed reader and an alarm clock. There is a Web browser that can also be controlled through the minimal controls on the device. The browsing feature does not work too well. Sites with a mobile version work fine, but even those show up some compatibility issues. These extra features are automatically enabled when the player goes into idle mode which can be



set through the Web interface. A price of Rs 6,695 is a tad more than expected. Even then, it makes a very good gadget to sit in your living room. It could be a little more stylish though, but even then it is bound to give

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

satellite radios a run for their money. For this low one-time fee, you get a device that does so much and gives you free instant access to the humongous library of Internet radio stations.

Contact: Rashi Peripherals Pvt.Ltd
Phone: 022-67090909
E-mail: freecom@rptechindia.com
Web site: www.freecom.com
Price: Rs 6,695

HP LaserJet P1505n

Just Another Printer

The P1505n is a brand new network printer from HP which can also be used as a local printer using USB. It looks like any other laser printer—compact with a simple design and bland colour scheme.

The printer feels very light and has lots of plastic all over it. The

trays seem wobbly and weak, so the printer might not be ideal for rough use. The paper feeding mechanism works well even with few sheets of paper in the feeding tray.

In terms of print quality, it isn't too bad. There is an economical mode you can choose from for both the 600

dpi and 1200 dpi modes. There's a big degradation in quality but there isn't much difference in the speed anyway. The eco mode shows up big jagged edges in the curved text characters. The shades of black become a lot lighter.

Most prints take between 7 to 9 s from the time the print command is

given on the program to the paper being dropped out. There is a little difference in print quality between the 600 dpi and 1200 dpi print modes.

This printer serves as a network printer as well. Installation is simple and just requires plugging in the CAT5 cable. Firing up a test print gives you all the necessary informa-



tion. There is a Web interface that can be accessed through a Web browser. Network connection and quality settings

for the printer can be viewed and changed. IPv6 support has been integrated into the printer. The price for the HP

Zebronics Mupic Arcade

Does A Lot But Not Too Well

The Music Arcade is a PMP that also works as a handheld gaming console. It comes with 2 GB of inbuilt memory and a Mini-SD card slot for expansion.

The quality of the buttons is poor. The buttons for the volume control and playback controls are placed on the outside.

Playing games is difficult as holding down the small keys more than a single key at a time is close to impossible. For the games, there is a NES emulator built into it. Additional games can be downloaded and put on the PMP.

The Mupic Arcade can play audio and video other than playing games and viewing text files. The screen is pretty good for images and movie playback but there is some stuttering while

playing some of the videos. There are also other applications such as a calculator and a notepad. The PMP shows up as a USB drive on the operating system. Media files can be dumped into the respective folders through it.

An additional feature is the in-built camera. The camera can take still shots of resolutions up to 1600 x 1200. The maximum resolution for the videos is 320 x 240 and these are stored in the 3GP format. There are earplugs supplied with it—the audio is loud and they don't sound too shabby.

Overall, the player feels very cheap and has quite a few bugs and design flaws. It has quite a few features which you most likely won't use anyway.

Rs 5,400 is what you pay for the Mupic Arcade

P1505n is Rs 14,999 which is costly and would make no obvious sense for a home user. For office use, it's a comparatively cheap investment. For prints with images along with text, the quality is average, but for just plain text printouts it does a rather good job. If you already own a monochrome laser printer, then there's no real reason to move to this. For a SoHo environment, or even larger offices for that matter, this printer should make good sense as it removes a dedicated print server

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

from the equation.

Specifications
Resolution: 600 x 600 dpi, Memory: 8MB, 1 toner cartridge, Dimensions: 14.9 x 15.9 x 8.9 inches, Weight: 5.8 kg.
Contact: Hewlett Packard
Phone: +91-124-2566 111
E-mail: samir-s_shah@hp.com
Web site: www.hp.com/in
Price: Rs. 14,999



and that makes it really bad value for money when you compare it to the competition. For around Rs 2,000 to 3,000 more, you can get your hands on a Playstation Portable that comes with a much larger screen, is much more powerful, and has WiFi along with many other features.

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

It also looks much better and feels a lot more solidly built than the Mupic Arcade.

Specifications
Screen resolution: 320x240, 2 GB internal memory, Mini-SD expansion cards support, MP3 / WMA Audio format support
Contact: Zebronics (TopNotch Infotronics)
Phone: +91-44-26616201
E-mail: enquiry@zebrionics.info
Web site: www.zebrionics.com
Price: Rs 5,400